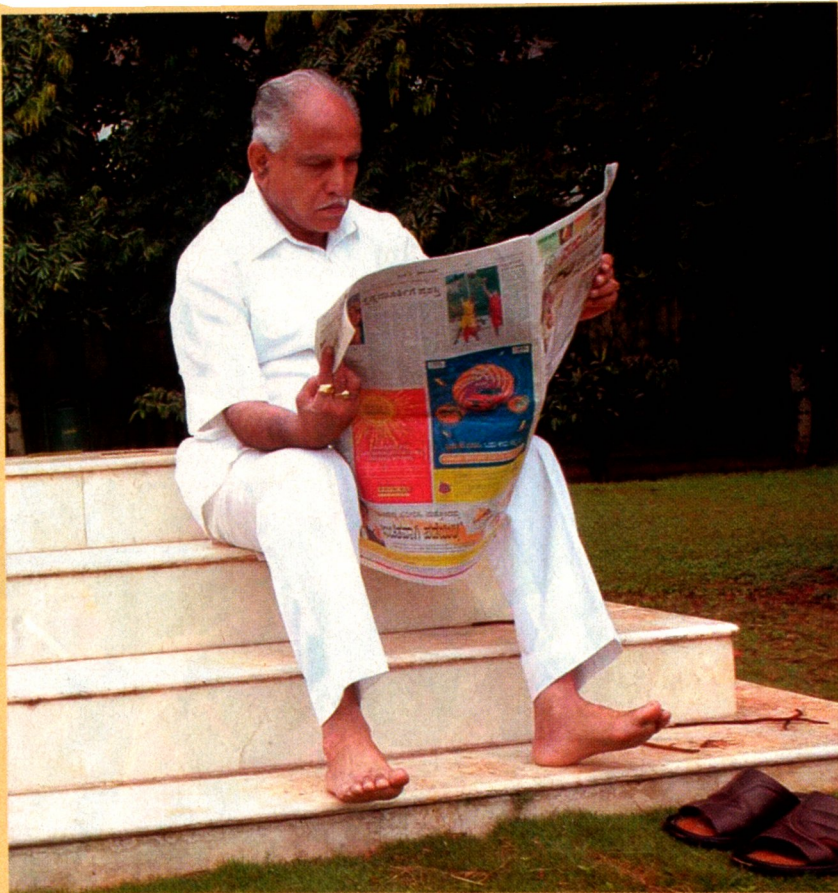


INTERVIEW | B.S. YEDDYURAPPA

"There are no coalition compulsions now...we will

To the people in his village of Bookanakere, B.S. Yeddyurappa is a son of the soil. To the Lingayat community, he is a poster boy in a state which has sharply divided caste rivalry with the Vokkaligas. To BJP, he is the face that won them the elections. Yeddyurappa's success story is as dramatic as they come. Born in a village in Mandya in a family of farmers in 1943, he did his schooling in Mandya and dropped out of high school to become a fruit seller. Having joined RSS in the early 1960s, he led a peasants' movement in his home town. He rose through the ranks to become one of the most powerful men in his party in the state. He has been an MLA since 1983, always contesting from the Shikaripura constituency which is his strongest base. In the years since then, BJP's strength in the state assembly has been on the rise and last November, he took over as chief minister under a power sharing agreement with the JD(S). A week after he was sworn in, he lost his chair as the JD(S) withdrew support. There is a general feeling that Yeddyurappa had been wronged by JD(S) that led to people voting for him this time around. Others feel it is his 20-month stint as deputy chief minister, when he introduced a number of social welfare schemes, which worked in his favour. The day after he resigned as chief minister last year, he was already drawing out a strategy and was asking people to give him a chance. It paid off. In personal life, Yeddyurappa is known to be a recluse who is fond of listening to Kannada folk music and spiritual poetry. A day before he was sworn in as chief minister he spoke with Principal Correspondent STEPHEN DAVID:

Q. What is the secret of the mandate?



B. K. RAMESH

A. This is a vote for development and stability. People wanted action, not drama. And I hope to be the change agent and help in the progress of the state. We are grateful to the people for giving the party a chance to form the first BJP Government in south India.

Q. What is your vision for Karnataka?

A. As a farmer, my first priority is to ensure a big boost to the agriculture and irrigation sectors. I will follow up whatever projects that need to be followed up to boost this sector. I want to develop second and third tier cities so that the state becomes one of

the most developed and industrialised states in the country. My Government will be pro-active as we have no coalition compulsion now.

Q. What about the urban-rural divide which is a stark reality?

A. The benefits of the cities must go to the rural areas. For example, I would like to see BRJs in rural areas, we will address regional imbalance.

Q. What about pending projects, like the Bangalore-Mysore expressway that has been stuck for years?

A. We will study whatever the pending issues are and will do everything in accordance with the law of the land and we would like to assure that

BJP SAYS THE GENERAL FEELING THAT HE HAD BEEN WRONGED BY JD(S) LED TO HIS VICTORY. OTHERS CITE HIS WORK AS DEPUTY CM TO HAVE GONE IN HIS FAVOUR.